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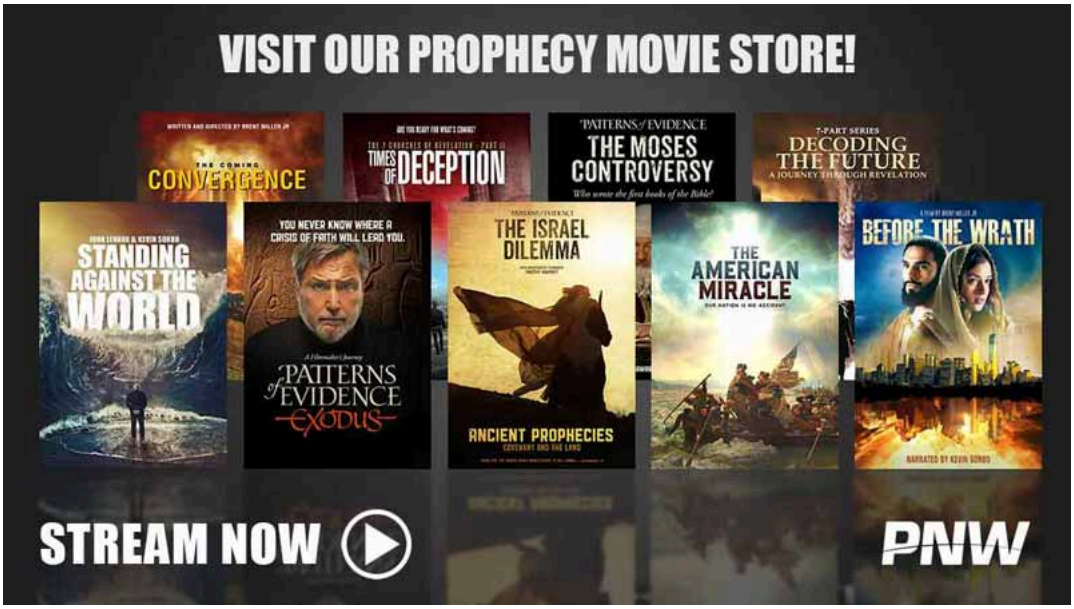

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ARTICLE

From Pulpit To Politics: How Progressive Christianity Is Distorting The Gospel

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BY PNW STAFF MARCH 17, 2026

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When a Christian minister enters politics, many voters expect that person to bring moral clarity shaped by faith. Pastors who step into public life often present themselves as moral voices capable of speaking truth into a divided culture.

But the public statements of Sarah Trone Garriott--a Lutheran pastor and Democratic candidate for Congress in Iowa's 3rd district--raise a deeper question: what happens when a minister redefines core Christian teachings to fit modern political ideology?

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Garriott, an ordained minister in the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America who currently serves in the Iowa State Senate, has built a political profile around progressive social positions, including strong support for abortion rights and LGBTQ activism. Yet it is her framing of Christian opposition to transgender ideology that has drawn the sharpest criticism.

A Pastor Who Sees Theology as "Racial Anxiety"

In remarks discussing evangelical Christianity and cultural change, Garriott argued that movements such as LGBTQ activism challenge traditional power structures. She suggested that questioning traditional definitions of men and women can be "very threatening" to the "white, male, powerful figure," because it disrupts conventional ideas about gender and authority.

In other discussions of religion and politics, critics say Garriott has suggested that evangelical resistance to LGBTQ ideology stems less from theology and more from racial or cultural anxiety.

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The historic Christian position on human sexuality and gender is not rooted in racial politics. It is rooted in Scripture.

For two thousand years the Christian tradition has taught that human beings are created male and female, a foundational idea drawn directly from the opening chapters of Genesis. Christians who affirm this belief are not expressing racial grievance. They are expressing theological conviction.

Reducing that belief to "white male anxiety" is not only inaccurate--it is dismissive.

A Misreading of Christian Tradition

Garriott's comments also fit into a broader narrative promoted by some progressive theologians: that evangelical Christianity is largely a political project built around power rather than belief.

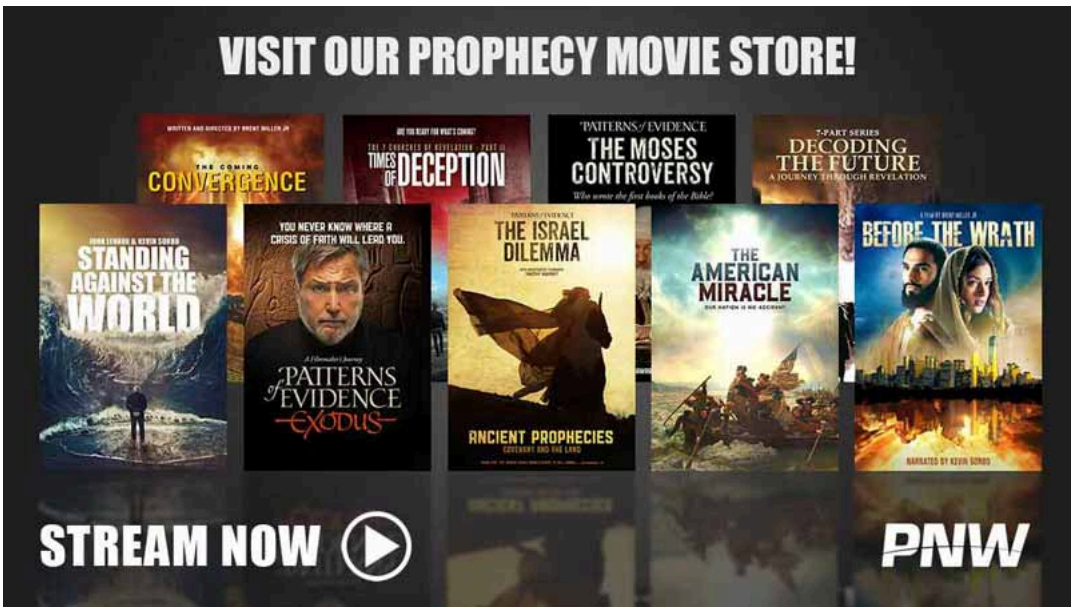
This interpretation ignores the global reality of Christianity.

Evangelical churches across Africa, Asia, and Latin America--many of which are led by non-white pastors and believers--hold exactly the same views about gender and marriage as American evangelicals. These churches represent hundreds of millions of Christians worldwide.

If opposition to transgender ideology were truly about protecting "white male power," those global churches would not share the same convictions.

Yet they do.

That alone undermines the argument.



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The Real Debate: Anthropology, Not Politics

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For [illegible] realities tied to reproduction, physiology, and family structure.

Transgender ideology challenges that framework by asserting that gender identity exists independently from biological sex.

That claim has profound implications for society. It affects everything from women's sports to medical ethics, parental rights, and the protection of children.

Christians who raise concerns about those issues are not acting out of fear of "white patriarchy." They are responding to what they see as a radical redefinition of the human person.

When Religion Becomes Political Messaging

The deeper concern raised by Garriott's comments is what happens when clergy reshape religious language to align with political ideology.

Throughout history, the church has wrestled with the temptation to adapt its teachings to cultural trends. Sometimes that accommodation leads to reform. Other times it leads to confusion.

When ministers begin dismissing traditional Christian beliefs as mere expressions of racial or gender anxiety, they risk replacing theology with sociology.

That shift may be politically convenient, but it comes at a cost.

Faith traditions survive because they anchor moral claims in something beyond political power. Once those claims are reduced to social dynamics, they lose their authority.

A Growing Trend in Progressive Christianity

Garriott's comments also reflect a larger and increasingly visible trend within American politics: a rising number of progressive politicians who openly claim Christian faith while simultaneously promoting ideas that directly contradict the biblical teachings they say they represent.

One prominent example is James Talarico, a Democratic state representative in Texas who frequently speaks about his Christian faith while advocating progressive social positions on issues such as sexuality and gender. Talarico often frames his arguments as a reclaiming of Christianity from conservatives, presenting progressive politics as the true expression of the Gospel.

But critics argue that this approach does something very different: it attempts to redefine Christianity itself.

Rather than wrestling with what Scripture actually says about human nature, marriage, and the created order, this new wave of progressive Christian politicians often reframes those teachings as outdated or misunderstood. Biblical texts are reinterpreted through the lens of modern political ideology rather than the historic teachings of the church.

The result is a kind of theological inversion. The authority of Scripture is affirmed rhetorically--but its plain meaning is quietly set aside.

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The concern arises when political leaders claim biblical authority while promoting ideas that directly contradict the very passages they say guide their faith.

That tension is now shaping a broader cultural debate inside American Christianity itself. On one side are progressive voices arguing that Christian teaching must evolve to reflect modern understandings of identity and sexuality. On the other are believers who argue that the church cannot simply rewrite foundational truths every time cultural winds shift.

The outcome of that debate will not be decided in political campaigns alone. It will be decided in churches, seminaries, and congregations across the country.

But as more political figures present progressive ideology as the true expression of Christianity, the question facing many believers is becoming increasingly clear:

At what point does redefining Scripture stop being interpretation--and start becoming contradiction?

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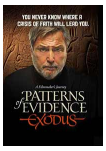

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